

2024 Patent Picks – Weird and Wonderful

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If ever proof were needed that innovation knows no bounds, look no further than our list of out-of-the-ordinary patents.

Improved Gloves and Mittens (1992)

Say goodbye to cold hands – and hello to romance. Patented by David King Terence in 1992, these “improved gloves and mittens” are made “for wear by a courting couple” who wish to hold hands in cold weather. “Intended to accommodate two hands”, the gloves feature two finger and thumb receiving areas enabling couples to walk “along hand-in-hand so that their palms are kept in contact but their hands are kept warm”. Can we pre-order them for Valentine’s Day?

Computer Workstations (2000)

Tired of sitting at your desk all day? Inventors David M. Baus, Gary T. Lobdell, and Kevin J. Gould have a solution: a computer workstation that lets you work from a nearly-fully reclined position. Featuring an adjustable wedge-type backrest with adjustable inclination, along with leg and arm supports, this invention promises to eliminate “the physical problems attributable to prolonged sitting at a computer terminal”. Lightweight, portable, and completely adjustable to your body size, this invention offers a whole new level of comfort for long workdays. Now you can work hard – and be laid-back!

Pillow With Retractable Umbrella (2004)

Sunbathing is great – but only if you’re properly equipped. Finding that current sunning accessories do not allow “a user to support his/her head while covering their face from sunlight”, Marielena Jane-Prats patented a pillow with a retractable umbrella. This invention keeps your head comfy while shading your face from the sun’s harsh rays. The pillow “may be stored in a case for easy carrying” and features “rotating and swivel means for umbrella positioning”. And that’s not all: it even includes a built-in storage compartment for your beach essentials. Can sunbathing get more relaxing than this?!

Back Cleaning, Brushing and Drying Device (2005)

Let’s face it – cleaning your back in the shower is no easy task. Michel Perrot seems to agree: in 2005, he patented a multi-functional device that can easily reach every inch of your back. Built around a “tubular rigid or semi-rigid ring”, the device holds brushes, sponges, and massaging rollers – and even “a shaving element such as an electric razor” to make your shower routine yet more effective. Finally, a tool that’s got your back!

Bed Suitcase (2009)

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Do you miss your bed while traveling? With María Dolores Álvarez's bed-suitcase, you can take your bed wherever you go: her novel suitcase contains "bed bases to be used at the time of sleeping". Complete with wheels and a carry handle, this suitcase will turn your next trip into the ultimate travel sleepover. Sweet dreams, travelers!

Communication Privacy Mask (2010)

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Having to take a private phone call in public can be awkward. But there's a solution: Joseph Manne's "communication privacy mask" is designed to prevent "the voice from being heard by others". Its microphone and sound tube are capable of delivering high-fidelity audio even "when used in environments with a substantial level of noise outside the mask." Whether you're in a noisy café or a quiet library, this mask keeps your conversation private while cutting out unwanted background noise. With Bluetooth connectivity and a head strap for hands-free use, this mask leaves nothing to be eavesdropped!

Potty-Type Device and Electronic System for Male Dogs (2016)

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Can you have a clean home and a dog? Yes – thanks to Luis Rodrigo Vázquez Bárcenas, who invented a "potty-type device" for male dogs featuring an electronic reward system. According to the inventor, the device "meets the needs of the owner relating to care, hygiene and practicality, and the natural needs of the dogs", creating "harmony in living spaces shared by owners and pets". To reward dogs on their best behavior, the system automatically dispenses edible treats to dogs who use it. Woof!

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